

Performance Conversation Guide

A structured guide for managers conducting performance conversations — preparation, delivery, active listening, and collaborative goal-setting.

1. Preparation Checklist

A performance conversation prepared in the ten minutes beforehand tends to default to vague impressions rather than specific evidence — and vague feedback is the single biggest reason these conversations land badly. Prepare properly, even for a routine check-in.

Item	Why It Matters
Gather 2-3 specific, evidenced examples per point you plan to raise	"You've been disengaged lately" is an impression; "you missed the last two team standups without notice" is evidence the person can actually respond to and act on
Review commitments and goals from the last conversation	Following up on what was agreed last time signals the conversation matters, not just the room you happen to be in
Check any relevant HR policy or process requirements	Some conversations (performance improvement, disciplinary-adjacent) have formal requirements that must be followed regardless of your personal style
Choose a private, uninterrupted setting and adequate time	A rushed or interruptible conversation signals it isn't a priority, regardless of what's actually said
Decide your 2-3 key messages in advance	If you can't summarize the point in a sentence beforehand, the conversation will likely wander and the person will leave unsure what actually mattered
Consider what you don't know	What might explain the gap in performance that you haven't considered? Walking in with genuine curiosity changes the tone of the whole conversation

2. Conversation Structure Guide

This structure deliberately asks for the other person's self-assessment before you share your own view. Leading with your assessment first anchors the conversation around your framing and makes it harder for the person to raise something you hadn't considered.

Stage	Purpose	Approx. Time
Opening	Set a collaborative tone and state the purpose plainly	2-3 min
Self-Assessment	Ask for their view first, before sharing yours	5-10 min
Your Perspective	Share specific, evidenced observations, both positive and constructive	10-15 min
Discussion	Genuinely two-way — respond to what they raised, don't just deliver a monologue	10-15 min
Forward Look	Agree goals and development actions collaboratively (see Section 4)	10 min
Close	Summarize what was agreed and confirm next steps and check-in timing	3-5 min

Opening Language

Examples to adapt, not read verbatim:

- *"I want this to be a two-way conversation — I'll share my perspective, but I want to hear yours first."*
- *"The purpose of today is to look at how the last quarter went and agree what we're focusing on next."*
- *"Nothing I'm going to raise should be a surprise — if it is, that's on me for not raising it sooner, and I want to know that."*

Common Pitfalls

- Leading with your assessment before asking for theirs, which anchors the whole conversation around your framing
- Softening constructive feedback into vagueness to avoid discomfort, leaving the person unclear what actually needs to change
- Turning "discussion" into a monologue with pauses only for the other person to acknowledge what you've said
- Ending without a clear, specific summary of what was actually agreed

3. Active Listening Prompts

These techniques matter most in the Self-Assessment and Discussion stages, where the goal is genuinely understanding the other person's view, not waiting for your turn to talk.

Paraphrasing (confirms understanding)

- *"What I'm hearing is — does that sound right?"*
- *"So if I understand correctly, the main blocker was..."*
- *"Let me check I've got this: you felt the priority shifted without much notice?"*

Open Questions (invites real detail, not yes/no)

- *"What's your take on how that project went?"*
- *"What would need to be different for this to feel more manageable?"*
- *"What's gotten in the way of that, from your side?"*

Acknowledging Emotion (without necessarily agreeing with the conclusion)

- *"It sounds like that's been genuinely frustrating."*
- *"I can hear this matters a lot to you."*
- *"That makes sense that you'd feel that way, given what happened."*

Using Silence

After asking a real question, resist the urge to fill silence with another question or your own answer. A pause of even five seconds often produces a more honest, considered response than the first thing someone says to avoid an awkward gap.

4. Goal-Setting Framework

Goals set collaboratively are more likely to actually stick than goals handed down — ask what the person thinks the goal should be before proposing your own version. If you land in the same place, it's now their goal too, not just an instruction.

The Four Elements

Element	The Question It Answers
Goal	What, specifically, will be different or achieved?
Success Measure	How will both of you know, concretely, that it's been met?
Support Needed	What does the person need from you or others to actually get there?
Check-in Date	When will you both revisit this, before it's too late to adjust course?

Goal-Setting Template

Goal	Success Measure	Support Needed	Check-in Date
Example: Lead the next client presentation independently	Delivers the presentation with only light review from manager beforehand	Sit in on two more presentations as an observer first; feedback session after each	In 6 weeks

Common Pitfalls

- Setting the goal before asking what the person thinks it should be
- A success measure vague enough that both sides could later disagree about whether it was met
- No specific check-in date, so the goal quietly disappears until the next formal review